

Materia Medica III – Blood-Tonifying Herbs

Overview

Blood-tonifying herbs nourish and replenish blood, regulate menstruation, alleviate pain related to deficiency, and support recovery from chronic illness. They primarily affect the **Liver, Heart, and Spleen**, and many secondarily **nourish yin**.

General Characteristics

Attribute	Description
Taste	Sweet (often acrid or bitter as secondary)
Temperature	Warm (most), Neutral–Cool (select)
Channels	Liver, Heart, Spleen
Core Actions	Tonify blood; nourish yin; regulate menses

Global Cautions

- Blood tonics can be **cloying** → watch for Spleen deficiency, dampness, or loose stools.
 - Warm blood tonics may **aggravate heat** or yin-deficient heat.
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Blood-Tonifying Herbs – Quick Reference Table

Herb	Nature	Channels	Core Exam Keywords
Dang Gui	Warm	LV, HT, SP	Tonifies & invigorates blood; regulates menses; alleviates pain
Shu Di Huang	Slightly warm	LV, KD	Strong blood & yin tonic; replenishes Jing; fills marrow
Bai Shao	Slightly cold	LV, SP	Nourishes blood; preserves yin; relieves spasms
He Shou Wu (Zhi)	Slightly warm	LV, KD	Nourishes blood & Jing; benefits hair

Herb	Nature	Channels	Core Exam Keywords
E Jiao	Neutral	LU, LV, KD	Nourishes blood; stops bleeding; moistens dryness
Long Yan Rou	Warm	HT, SP	Tonifies qi & blood; calms Shen

Dāng Guī 当归

Radix Angelicae Sinensis | *Chinese angelica root*

Nature & Flavor: Sweet, acrid, warm

Channels: Heart, Liver, Spleen

Primary Actions

1. **Tonifies blood and disperses cold**
2. **Invigorates blood and alleviates pain**
3. **Regulates menstruation**
4. **Moistens Intestines**
5. **Reduces swelling, expels pus, generates flesh**

Key Indications

- Blood deficiency: dizziness, pale complexion, palpitations
- Gynecologic disorders: dysmenorrhea, irregular menses, amenorrhea
- Pain due to blood deficiency or cold from deficiency
- Constipation due to blood deficiency

Processing

- **Dang Gui Shen:** Tonifies blood
- **Dang Gui Wei:** Invigorates blood
- **Quan Dang Gui:** Harmonizes blood

Dosage

- 5–15 g

Contraindications

- Excess patterns; yin-deficient heat
- Caution with diarrhea or abdominal distention

Exam Pearl

*Dang Gui both **tonifies and moves** blood—think deficiency **with** pain.*

Shú Dì Huáng 熟地黄

Radix Rehmanniae Preparata | *Prepared rehmannia*

Nature & Flavor: Sweet, slightly warm

Channels: Liver, Kidney

Primary Actions

1. **Strongly tonifies blood**
2. **Nourishes Liver & Kidney yin**
3. **Replenishes Jing; fills marrow**

Key Indications

- Severe blood deficiency with dizziness, insomnia, menstrual disorders
- Kidney yin deficiency with heat signs
- Essence deficiency: low back pain, tinnitus, premature graying

Dosage

- 10–30 g

Processing Notes

- **Charred Shu Di:** Stops bleeding
- Combine with **Chen Pi** or **Sha Ren** to protect the Middle Jiao

Contraindications

- Dampness, phlegm, qi stagnation
- Weak digestion

Exam Pearl

*Shu Di = strongest blood & essence tonic, but **most cloying***

Hé Shǒu Wū 何首乌 (Zhi)

Radix Polygoni Multiflori Preparata | *Processed fleeceflower*

Nature & Flavor: Bitter, sweet, astringent, slightly warm

Channels: Liver, Kidney

Primary Actions

1. **Nourishes blood & replenishes Jing (essence)**
2. **Benefits hair**
3. **Moistens Intestines**
4. **Eliminates fire toxins & malarial disorders**
5. **Tonifies the Liver and Kidneys**

Key Indications

- Premature graying, dizziness, weakness in the lower back and knees
- Constipation from blood deficiency
- Used for fire toxins such as carbuncles, sores, and goiter

Processing Distinction (Critical)

- **Sheng He Shou Wu:** Clears toxins, moves bowels (NOT a tonic); it is bitter and has a strong action to eliminate heat
- **Zhi He Shou Wu:** Tonifies blood & essence; strengthens Liver & Kidney, benefits hair

Dosage

- 10–30 g

Contraindications

- Spleen deficiency with loose stools
- Dampness or phlegm

Bái Sháo 白芍

Radix Paeoniae Alba | *White peony root*

Nature & Flavor: Bitter, sour, slightly cold

Channels: Liver, Spleen

Primary Actions

1. **Nourishes blood & regulates menses**
2. **Preserves yin, stops sweating**
3. **Tonifies the Liver blood; softens the Liver; alleviates spasms**
4. **Tonifies the Liver & calms Liver yang**

Key Indications

- Menstrual disorders with deficiency
- Muscle cramps, abdominal pain

- Liver qi constraint with deficiency
- Spontaneous or night sweating

Dosage

- 5–10 g (up to 30 g)

Contraindications

- Yang deficiency with cold
- Incompatible with **Li Lu**

Exam Pearl

*Bai Shao treats **pain from deficiency**, not stasis.*

Ē Jiāo 阿胶

Colla Corii Asini | *Donkey-hide gelatin*

Nature & Flavor: Sweet, neutral

Channels: Lung, Liver, Kidney

Primary Actions

1. **Nourishes & tonifies the blood**
2. **Stops bleeding**
3. **Nourishes Yin; Moistens dryness (Lung)**

Key Indications

- Bleeding from deficiency (uterine, coughing blood)
- Blood deficiency with dryness

Dosage

- 3–9 g (melt separately in the warm decoction or hot water)

Contraindications

- E Jiao is cloying and is contraindicated with Spleen and Stomach deficiencies that manifest as loose stools, diarrhea, or poor appetite
- Dampness, phlegm, poor digestion

Lóng Yǎn Ròu 龙眼肉

Arillus Longan | *Longan fruit*

Nature & Flavor: Sweet, warm

Channels: Heart, Spleen

Primary Actions

1. **Tonifies qi & blood**
2. **Tonifies the Heart and Spleen**
3. **Calms Shen**

Key Indications

- Insomnia, anxiety, palpitations from deficiency
- Poor memory, fatigue

Dosage

- 9–15 g
- Max dose for Long Yan Rou is 30g. It is also used in paste, grain-based liquor, or pill form.

Contraindications

- Phlegm-fire, middle jiao dampness, or pill forms
- Long Yan Rou is warm, so it is contraindicated in cases of excess or deficiency heat and in exterior conditions.

Exam Pearl

*Think **blood deficiency + Shen disturbance***

Comparisons

- **Dang Gui vs. Shu Di:** Moving vs. cloying; pain vs. essence
 - **Dang Gui vs. Bai Shao:** Moves blood vs. preserves yin
 - **He Shou Wu vs. Shu Di:** Hair/Jing vs. marrow/essence
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